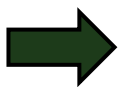
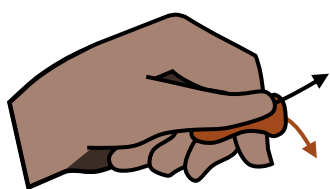




The Ribbon Test Flow Chart

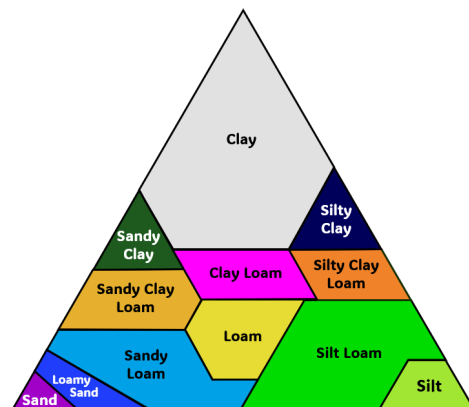
Identifying Soil Texture by Feel!



Soil Ribbon

(1) Place two teaspoons of soil in your palm. (2) Add a few drops of water and (3) knead soil to break down aggregates. (4) Soil is at proper consistency when it feels plastic and moldable, like moist putty.

Add more dry soil to soak up the extra water



Does the soil remain in a ball when squeezed?

No

Is the soil too dry?

No

Is the soil too wet?

No

Sand

High

(1) Place ball of soil between thumb and forefinger (2) gently push the soil with your thumb upward into a ribbon. (3) Try to shape the ribbon into uniform thickness & width. (4) Allow the ribbon to extend over forefinger & break from its own weight. (5) Does the soil form a ribbon?

No

Loamy Sand

Yes

Does the soil make a weak ribbon < 1" long before breaking?

No

Does the soil make a medium ribbon 1-2" long before breaking?

No

Does the soil make a large ribbon > 2" long before breaking?

% Sand

Fully saturate a small pinch of soil in your palm & rub it with your forefinger.

Does soil feel very gritty?

Yes

Sandy Loam

No

Neither gritty nor smooth?

Yes

Loam

No

Does soil feel very smooth?

Yes

Silt Loam

Does soil feel very gritty?

Yes

Sandy Clay Loam

No

Neither gritty nor smooth?

Yes

Clay Loam

No

Does soil feel very smooth?

Yes

Silty Clay Loam

Does soil feel very gritty?

Yes

Sandy Clay

No

Neither gritty nor smooth?

Yes

Clay

No

Does soil feel very smooth?

Yes

Silty Clay

Low

Low

% Clay

High

Based on Key Resources from:

Agriculture NSW Water Unit. (2015). *Determining soil texture using the ribboning technique* (Primefact 1363). NSW Department of Primary Industries.

Soil Texture By Feel Flow Chart. (2013). Oregon State University.

Last Updated: 08/31/2026 by Percy Smith